MODULE 2

BUILDING STRONG ARGUMENTS

Learning Goals

- **Understand what makes an argument strong.**
- Identify the difference between an **opinion** and an **argument**.
- Use the **Claim** → **Reason** → **Example** structure.
- Develop ideas for a debate topic and consider **both sides**.
- Give relevant **examples** and use simple **evidence**.
- Organise **two or three arguments** logically.
- Explain **why a point matters**.
- Turn a simple opinion into a **stronger debate argument**.

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1. What Is an Argument?

An **argument** is a clear idea or position that you explain and support. In a debate, you do not simply say what you think. You explain **why** you think it and give support for your point.

Opinion: “School uniforms are good.”

Argument: “School uniforms can reduce pressure on students to wear expensive clothes because everyone follows the same dress code.”

A strong debate argument usually answers two basic questions:

- **WHAT** do you believe?
- **WHY** do you believe it?

The why is what turns a simple opinion into an argument.

2. Opinion vs. Argument

An **opinion** tells us what you think. An **argument** tells us what you think and gives a reason or support.

Type	Example
Opinion	“Homework is boring.”
Argument	“Too much homework can reduce students’ time for sleep and physical activity.”
Opinion	“School uniforms are better.”
Argument	“School uniforms can make students feel equal because everyone follows the same dress code.”

Remember: In a debate, do not stop at “I think…”. Add a clear reason and, when possible, an example or evidence.

3. The Three-Part Argument

One of the easiest ways to build a strong beginner argument is:

CLAIM → REASON → EXAMPLE

CLAIM: What you believe.

REASON: Why you believe it.

EXAMPLE: A real, practical, or familiar situation that supports your point.

Example

Claim: Students should have regular sports periods.

Reason: Physical activity helps students stay active and can improve concentration.

Example: After a short sports session, students may return to class feeling more energetic and ready to learn.

4. How to Develop an Argument

When you receive a debate topic, develop your idea step by step.

Step 1 — WHAT? State your position clearly.

Step 2 — WHY? Give a reason for your position.

Step 3 — HOW? Explain how the reason connects to the topic.

Step 4 — EXAMPLE? Give a situation that makes your point easy to understand.

Step 5 — RESULT? Explain what happens because of your point.

Topic: Students should read every day.

Claim: Daily reading is useful for students.

Reason: It can improve vocabulary and understanding.

Example: A student who reads regularly meets new words in context.

Result: Over time, the student can understand and use more vocabulary.

5. The “Why?” Technique

If your argument feels too simple, ask yourself **“Why?”** again. This helps you move from a basic statement to a deeper explanation.

Statement: “Students should exercise.”

Why? “Because exercise keeps the body active.”

Why is that important? “Because regular activity supports a healthy lifestyle.”

How can we see this? “Students can walk, play sports, or take part in physical activities regularly.”

> **You do not always need to ask “why?” many times. Stop when your explanation is clear, relevant, and useful.**

6. Strong Reasons vs. Weak Reasons

A good reason should connect directly to the topic. It should help the audience understand **why your claim matters**.

Weak	Stronger
“School uniforms are good because I like them.”	“School uniforms can reduce pressure about clothing choices.”

Weak	Stronger
“Books are important because books are important.”	“Reading regularly can improve vocabulary and comprehension.”
“Homework is bad because I don't like homework.”	“Too much homework can reduce time for rest and other activities.”

Check your reason:

- Does it directly support my **claim**?
- Can I **explain** it clearly?
- Can I give an **example**?
- Does it explain **why the point matters**?

7. Look at Both Sides

Good debaters understand that a **motion** can be viewed from different perspectives. Before speaking, think about what the **For** side might say and what the **Against** side might say.

Motion: “Students should be allowed to use mobile phones at school.”

FOR: Phones can support learning, research, and communication.

AGAINST: Phones can distract students and reduce attention in class.

> **Useful question: “What might the other side say?”**

Thinking about the other side helps you prepare **better reasons** and anticipate possible **counterarguments**.

8. Using Examples

An example makes an argument easier to understand. It shows the audience **how your idea could work in a real situation**.

Without an example: “Reading improves communication.”

With an example: “Reading exposes students to new words and sentence patterns. For example, a student who reads stories regularly may learn how to express ideas more clearly.”

Useful phrases for examples:

- **For example, …**
- **For instance, …**
- **A simple example is …**
- **We can see this when …**
- **Imagine a situation where …**

9. Using Evidence

Evidence is information that supports a claim. For beginners, evidence can include **facts, observations, examples, survey results, research findings, or reliable statistics**.

Argument: “Regular physical activity is useful for students.”

Supporting evidence: A reliable health or education source reports that regular physical activity has benefits for children and young people.

Important: Evidence should be relevant to your argument and come from a reliable source.

Never invent facts or statistics to make an argument sound stronger.

10. Organising Your Arguments

If you have several points, organise them so the audience can follow your thinking easily.

POINT 1 → POINT 2 → POINT 3

Example: Motion — Students should read every day.

- **Point 1:** Reading can improve vocabulary.
- **Point 2:** Reading can improve understanding.
- **Point 3:** Reading can develop imagination and creativity.

Connect your points with simple transitions such as **Firstly, Secondly, Finally**.

11. Choosing the Order of Your Arguments

The order of your arguments can make your speech easier to follow.

- **Start with a clear argument.**
- **Develop your ideas in a logical order.**
- **Finish with an important or memorable point.**

Example:

Firstly — Health: Sports help students stay active.

Secondly — Learning: Physical activity can help students return to class with energy.

Finally — Teamwork: Team sports give students opportunities to cooperate with others.

12. Useful Phrases for Building Arguments

Starting an argument

- **Firstly, I believe that …**
- **My first point is that …**

- **One important reason is …**

Giving a reason

- **This is because …**
- **The main reason is …**
- **This matters because …**

Giving an example

- **For example, …**
- **For instance, …**

Explaining importance

- **This is important because …**
- **As a result, …**
- **This can help …**

13. Turn a Weak Argument into a Strong Argument

Weak: “Students should read because reading is good.”

Step 1 — Claim: Students should read regularly.

Step 2 — Reason: Reading can improve vocabulary and understanding.

Step 3 — Example: Students who read different types of texts regularly meet new words and ideas.

Final argument: “Students should read regularly because reading can improve vocabulary and understanding. For example, students who read different types of texts meet new words and ideas.”

14. Argument Builder Activity

Motion: “Students should have less homework.”

Your task: Complete the four parts below.

CLAIM: _____

REASON: _____

EXAMPLE: _____

RESULT: _____

Challenge: Give your argument to a partner. Ask your partner: “Is the reason clear?” and “Does the example support the point?”

15. Build Three Arguments

Motion: “School students should have a daily reading period.”

Argument 1 — Vocabulary

Claim: A daily reading period can improve vocabulary.

Reason: Students meet new words in meaningful contexts.

Example: Stories, articles, and books introduce words that students can later use in speaking and writing.

Argument 2 — Understanding

Claim: Reading can improve understanding.

Reason: Students practise following ideas and information.

Example: Regular reading helps students identify the main idea and important details.

Argument 3 — Creativity

Claim: Reading can develop imagination.

Reason: Stories encourage students to picture situations and think about different possibilities.

Example: A story can make students imagine places, characters, and events.

16. Challenge — Build Your First Strong Argument

Choose one motion:

- Students should have a four-day school week.
- Every student should learn a sport.
- Schools should allow more creative activities.
- Students should read for 20 minutes every day.
- Homework should be limited on weekends.

Build your argument:

CLAIM → REASON → EXAMPLE → RESULT

- **Claim:** What do you believe?
- **Reason:** Why do you believe it?
- **Example:** What situation supports your idea?
- **Result:** Why does your point matter?

> **Speaking challenge: Deliver your argument in 30–45 seconds. Speak clearly, use complete sentences, and look at your audience.**

KEY TAKEAWAY

A **strong argument** is more than an opinion. It gives a clear point, explains **why**, supports the idea with an **example or evidence**, and shows **why the point matters**.

CLAIM → REASON → EXAMPLE → RESULT

Think. Explain. Support. Convince.